

STRONG NOT SORRY.

8 weeks. 4 days a week.

Build real strength. Stop apologizing for taking up space.

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Feminine Strength Co.

INCLUDES

- Weeks 1–4: Foundation
- Week 5: Deload
- Weeks 6–8: Progression
- RPE + Coaching Cues

Form over weight. Always.

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"Stability over intensity. Form over weight. Always." — This is the whole program in two sentences.

STRONG NOT SORRY · 8-WEEK STRENGTH PROGRAM

HOW TO USE THIS PROGRAM

The approach, the rules, what to expect

01

"Stability over intensity."

01 — THE APPROACH

This is not a workout plan. It's a strength practice.

There's a difference between going to the gym and training. Going to the gym is showing up and doing things. Training is showing up with a plan, executing it, tracking what happened, and coming back next time to do it better.

This is an 8-week strength program built on four training days a week — two lower body sessions and two upper body sessions. The split is simple on purpose. Simple is what you can sustain. Simple is what actually builds the body.

"Stability over intensity. The goal is to earn the right to go heavier — not to go heavier before you've earned it."

The Non-Negotiables

- Form before weight. Every time. If the form breaks, the weight comes down — no exceptions, no ego.
- RPE is your guide. Rate of Perceived Exertion on a 1–10 scale. Most sets should feel like a 7–8. You should finish feeling like you had 1–2 reps left in the tank.
- Rest between sets. 60–90 seconds for isolation work. 2–3 minutes for compound lifts. Rest is part of the program.
- Track your weights. Write them down. The program only works if you know what you lifted last week.
- Do the deload. Week 5 is not a light week you can skip. It's where your body consolidates the work from weeks 1–4. Skip it and weeks 6–8 will suffer.

What This Program Is Not

- It's not a cardio program. Cardio lives on your off days and in your step count — not inside these sessions.
- It's not a fat loss program on its own. Pair it with The Standard Fat Loss System for the full picture.
- It's not meant to be done seven days a week. Four days is the program. The other three days are recovery, movement, and rest.

More is not better. Better is better. Four focused days will outperform seven sloppy ones every single time.

STRONG NOT SORRY · 8-WEEK STRENGTH PROGRAM

ABOUT THAT WEIGHT

Why heavier is not the same as bulky

02

"Stability over intensity."

02 — ABOUT THAT WEIGHT

Put down the 5-pound dumbbells.

I need to say this before you touch a single exercise in this program, because if I don't, you'll do 8 weeks of work with 8-pound dumbbells and wonder why nothing changed.

When I say heavier, I am not asking you to bulk up like the Incredible Hulk. I'm not asking you to look like a bodybuilder or some gigantic man. I'm asking you to put down the 5s and 8s and 10s... and work your way down the weight rack toward the 20s, the 25s, the 30s. That's the goal. That's what actually changes your body.

A muscle that isn't challenged has no reason to change. None. Zero. If the weight is easy, your body is not adapting.

Let's talk about getting bulky.

The fear that picking up a heavier weight is going to turn you into something unrecognizable is one of the most persistent myths in women's fitness... and it has kept women in the 5-to-10-pound range for decades, spinning their wheels, doing the same workouts, and getting the same results.

Here's what's actually true: the everyday woman does not have the hormonal environment to build the kind of muscle mass you're picturing. Testosterone is the primary driver of that kind of size. Women have a fraction of it. The women you've seen who look that way have trained specifically for that outcome for years, with nutrition designed around gaining mass. That is not what we're doing here.

What picking up a 25-pound dumbbell is going to do? Build the kind of muscle that makes your body feel different in your clothes. Raise your resting metabolism. Improve your insulin sensitivity. Make you stronger in ways you'll notice every single day. That's it.

There is no way the average woman is going to get big and bulky from picking up a 25 or 30 pound dumbbell. It is not going to happen.

Work your way down the weight rack.

Most gyms have dumbbells arranged lightest to heaviest. Most women grab from the left side of that rack every single session and never move right. This program asks you to start moving right.

Not all at once. Not recklessly. Safety first, always — form breaks before weight increases, every time, no exceptions. But the goal over these 8 weeks is to consistently challenge what you're capable of... and what you're capable of is more than you think.

Where to start:

Exercise Type	Where Most Women Start	Where We're Going
Upper body (rows, presses)	8–12 lbs	20–35 lbs over 8 weeks

Shoulder work (lateral raises, press)	5–8 lbs	12–20 lbs over 8 weeks
Lower body (RDLs, lunges, squats)	15–20 lbs	40–70 lbs over 8 weeks
Hip thrust / glute bridge	25–35 lbs	75–135 lbs over 8 weeks

These are ranges, not rules. Where you land depends on where you're starting. The point is direction — always moving toward more challenge, never staying comfortable.

Save the light weights for your warm-up.

The 3s, the 5s, the 8s have a place. That place is warming up your joints and getting blood moving before your working sets. They are not your working sets. The cute little color-coded rack by the mirror is for warm-ups... then you go find the real weights.

Form over weight, always. But form over weight doesn't mean stay light forever. It means earn the heavier weight with solid form — then pick it up.

STRONG NOT SORRY · 8-WEEK STRENGTH PROGRAM

THE WEEKLY SCHEDULE

4 days, what falls where, how to adapt it

03

"Stability over intensity."

03 — WEEKLY SCHEDULE

4 Days. Every Week.

The split is Lower / Upper / Lower / Upper. The days you assign them to are flexible — what isn't flexible is keeping at least one rest or active recovery day between your Lower B and next Lower A, and between Upper B and Upper A.

MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
LOWER A Hip dominant Sqaut focus 45–55 min	ACTIVE RECOVERY 20–30 min walk + mobility	UPPER A Push + Pull 45–55 min	REST or light walk	LOWER B Quad dominant 45–55 min	UPPER B Pull focused 45–55 min	REST + RESET
8–10k steps	8–10k steps	8–10k steps	8–10k steps	8–10k steps	8–10k steps	8–10k steps

How to Adapt It

- Can't do Mon/Tue/Thu/Fri? Any split works as long as you're not doing two lower or two upper sessions back to back.
- Missed a day? Slide it forward — don't skip it. Two lower days in a row beats skipping Lower B entirely.
- Travel week? Bodyweight or hotel gym variations are in the app. The structure stays the same.

Day Type	What It Means	Time Commitment
Strength Day	Full session — warm up, work sets, finisher	45–55 min
Active Recovery	Walk, mobility, light movement — nothing that creates soreness	20–30 min
Rest Day	Actual rest. Steps are fine. Nothing structured.	—
Deload Week (Wk 5)	Same movements, ~60% of your working weight	30–40 min

Warm-up: 5–8 minutes before every session. Walk, light bike, or a circuit of bodyweight squats + arm circles + hip hinges. Don't skip it — cold muscles under load is how injuries happen.

STRONG NOT SORRY · 8-WEEK STRENGTH PROGRAM

WEEKS 1–4: FOUNDATION

Build the base. Own the movement. Establish your weights.

04

"Stability over intensity."

04 — FOUNDATION

Build the base.

Weeks 1–4 are about learning the patterns and establishing your working weights. Prioritize control over load. Use RPE 7–8 — you should finish each set feeling like you had 1–2 reps left with good form.

Rep ranges hold for all 4 weeks. Week-over-week you're adding weight when the top of the range feels easy, not chasing new maxes.

WEEKS 1–4

FOUNDATION

Lower Body A — Hip Dominant · Day 1

Exercise	Sets × Reps	RPE	Coaching Cue	Progression
Romanian Deadlift (BB or DB)	3 × 10	7–8	Hinge at hips, soft knee, feel hamstring load before you pull	Add 5–10% when top of range feels easy with 2 reps in tank
Hip Thrust (BB or DB)	3 × 12	7–8	Drive through heel, squeeze at top, chin tucked	Progress to barbell when DB feels light
Single-Leg Glute Bridge	3 × 10 ea.	6–7	Control the descent, don't let the hip drop	Add DB across hip for load
Hamstring Curl (DB or Machine)	3 × 12	7	Full range, slow on the way down	Add weight when all reps feel controlled
Plank Hold	3 × 30–45s	—	Breathe. Ribs down. Don't hold your breath.	Extend hold by 5s each week

Upper Body A — Push + Pull · Day 2

Exercise	Sets × Reps	RPE	Coaching Cue	Progression
DB or BB Bench Press	3 × 10	7–8	Retract shoulder blades, controlled descent to chest	Add 5 lbs when all sets feel strong
One-Arm DB Row	3 × 10 ea.	7–8	Pull elbow to hip — feel the lat, not the shoulder	Increase weight weekly
Seated DB Shoulder Press	3 × 12	7	Don't flare the ribs, press straight up	Move to standing when form is solid
Cable or Band Face Pulls	3 × 15	6	External rotation at top, shoulders back and down	Add band resistance or cable weight
Tricep Pushdown	3 × 12	7	Elbows at sides — don't swing	Add weight when form stays clean

Lower Body B — Quad Dominant · Day 4

Exercise	Sets × Reps	RPE	Coaching Cue	Progression
Goblet Squat or BB Back Squat	3 × 10	7–8	Chest up, knees track toes, breathe at the top	Goblet → BB back squat as strength builds
Reverse Lunge (DB)	3 × 10 ea.	7	Step back not out — front shin stays vertical	Add weight or move to walking lunge
Step-Up to Knee Drive	3 × 10 ea.	6–7	Drive through heel on the box, controlled step down	Increase box height or add weight
Leg Press or DB Sumo Squat	3 × 12	7	Full depth, push the floor away	Add plate or DB weight weekly
Dead Bug	3 × 8 ea.	—	Low back on the floor — breathe out as you extend	Slow tempo to 3–4 sec per rep

Upper Body B — Pull Focused · Day 5

Exercise	Sets × Reps	RPE	Coaching Cue	Progression
Lat Pulldown or Assisted Pull-Up	3 × 10	7–8	Lean back slightly, pull to upper chest, lats do the work	Reduce assistance weekly
Seated Cable Row or DB Row	3 × 12	7–8	Squeeze shoulder blades together at the end	Add weight when all reps feel controlled
Lateral Raises (DB)	3 × 15	6–7	Lead with elbow, slight forward lean, control the drop	Add 2.5 lbs when form is clean
DB Bicep Curl	3 × 12	7	Full range, don't swing — own the bottom position	Add weight weekly
Bird Dog	3 × 8 ea.	—	Slow and controlled, don't let the hip rotate	Add 2-sec hold at extension

Track your weights after every session. You cannot progress what you cannot measure.

STRONG NOT SORRY · 8-WEEK STRENGTH PROGRAM

WEEK 5: DELOAD

Same movements. 60% effort. Don't skip it.

05

"Stability over intensity."

05 — DELOAD

Your body is catching up.

The deload is not a light week you can skip because you're feeling good. It's the week your nervous system, connective tissue, and muscles consolidate everything from weeks 1–4. Skip it and weeks 6–8 will feel harder than they should.

Same four days. Same movements. Same order. Drop to roughly 60% of your week 4 working weight. Full range of motion, full control, zero heroics.

WEEK 5

DELOAD — ~60% of working weight, full control

Day	Session	Deload Instruction
Day 1	Lower A — Hip Dominant	Same exercises as weeks 1–4. ~60% load. 3 × 10 on everything. Focus on feel, not weight.
Day 2	Upper A — Push + Pull	Same exercises as weeks 1–4. ~60% load. Slow the tempo down — 3 sec lowering on every rep.
Day 4	Lower B — Quad Dominant	Same exercises as weeks 1–4. ~60% load. Perfect depth on every squat and lunge variation.
Day 5	Upper B — Pull Focused	Same exercises as weeks 1–4. ~60% load. Full range of motion, pause at the top of every pull.

Signs your deload is working:

- You feel slightly bored — that's correct. Bored means you're recovered.
- Movements feel smooth and controlled at lighter weights — that's your nervous system consolidating the pattern.
- You're itching to go heavier — save it. That energy is exactly what weeks 6–8 need.

The deload is not optional. It's not a setback. It's part of the program — and it's part of why weeks 6–8 work.

STRONG NOT SORRY · 8-WEEK STRENGTH PROGRAM

WEEKS 6–8: PROGRESSION

Elevated variations. More demand. Same discipline.

06

"Stability over intensity."

06 — PROGRESSION

Same patterns. More demand.

Weeks 6–8 aren't a different program — they're the next level of the same one. Same movement patterns, elevated execution. Not more volume, not more days. More challenge within the same structure.

Expect weeks 6–8 to feel harder than weeks 1–4 even at similar weights. That's the tempo work, the single-leg demands, and the removed supports doing their job.

WEEKS 6–8

PROGRESSION — harder variations, more instability, greater range of motion

Lower Body A — Hip Dominant · Day 1

Exercise	Sets × Reps	RPE	Coaching Cue	Progression
Deficit RDL or Single-Leg RDL	3 × 10	8	Stand on a small plate for deficit. Single-leg: hip stays square, don't rotate.	Increase deficit height or reduce support weekly
Single-Leg Hip Thrust	3 × 10 ea.	8	Drive through working heel only. Control the descent — no dropping.	Add weight across hip when stable for all reps
Hamstring Curl — 3-sec lowering	3 × 10	7–8	Slow 3-second eccentric. The lowering phase is where the work happens.	Extend eccentric to 4 sec in week 8
Copenhagen or Side Plank	3 × 20–30s ea.	—	Hips stacked, body in a straight line. Don't let the hip drop.	Extend hold time each week
Dead Bug — slow tempo	3 × 8 ea.	—	5 seconds per rep. Low back stays completely flat the entire time.	Add light ankle weight in week 8

Upper Body A — Push + Pull · Day 2

Exercise	Sets × Reps	RPE	Coaching Cue	Progression
Tempo DB Press — 3-sec lowering	3 × 10	8	3 sec down, 1 sec pause at chest, press up. Same weight feels significantly harder.	Increase weight when tempo feels manageable across all sets
Unsupported Single-Arm DB Row	3 × 10 ea.	8	No bench support — hinge at hip, free-standing. More core demand throughout.	Add weight as stability improves
Arnold Press	3 × 12	7–8	Start palms facing you, rotate to palms forward as you press. Full rotation.	Add weight when full rotation stays controlled

Band Pull-Apart	3 × 15	6	Arms straight, pull apart at chest height. Squeeze shoulder blades at the end.	Increase band resistance
Overhead Tricep Extension	3 × 12	7	Elbows close to head, full range overhead. Don't let elbows flare out.	Add weight weekly

Lower Body B — Quad Dominant · Day 4

Exercise	Sets × Reps	RPE	Coaching Cue	Progression
Bulgarian Split Squat	3 × 10 ea.	8	Rear foot elevated, front foot forward. Start lighter than you think you need to.	Add DB weight when depth and control are consistent
Deficit Reverse Lunge	3 × 10 ea.	7–8	Stand on a small step. Greater range of motion, more quad demand than floor.	Increase step height or add weight
Step-Up with Pause at Top	3 × 10 ea.	7–8	Drive up, pause 2 sec at top with full hip extension, step down controlled.	Extend pause to 3 sec or add weight in week 8
Single-Leg Press	3 × 10 ea.	7–8	One leg at a time. Full depth. Working leg does all the work, no cheating.	Reduce assistance or add load weekly
Dead Bug — slow tempo	3 × 8 ea.	—	5 seconds per rep. Low back on the floor the entire time. No arch.	Add ankle weight in week 8

Upper Body B — Pull Focused · Day 5

Exercise	Sets × Reps	RPE	Coaching Cue	Progression
Pull-Up or Assisted Pull-Up	3 × 8	8	Full dead hang at the bottom, chin over bar at the top. Reduce assistance weekly.	Progress toward fully unassisted by week 8
Chest-Supported Row	3 × 10	8	Full retraction at the top. Heavy, controlled, no momentum. Chest stays on pad.	Add weight when all reps are clean
Cable Face Pull — wide grip	3 × 15	6–7	Wide external rotation at top. Pull to forehead, not chin. Elbows high.	Increase weight or band resistance
Hammer Curl	3 × 12	7	Neutral grip, full range. No swinging. Own the bottom position.	Add weight weekly
Pallov Press	3 × 10 ea.	—	Cable or band at chest height. Press out, hold 2 sec, return. Core braced throughout.	Increase cable weight or band tension

Progression rule: hit the top of every rep range with two reps left in the tank? Add 5–10% next week. No guessing, no maxing out, no heroics.

STRONG NOT SORRY · 8-WEEK STRENGTH PROGRAM

RECOVERY + CARDIO

What to do on your off days

07

"Stability over intensity."

07 — RECOVERY

Your off days are part of the program.

Rest and recovery are not the absence of training — they're where adaptation actually happens. The strength you're building shows up in the days after your session, not during it.

On your off days the goal is movement without additional training stress. Walk, stretch, mobilize. Not another workout.

Active Recovery Days

- 20–30 minute walk at a conversational pace — this is your LISS if you're also running The Standard Fat Loss System
- 5–10 minutes of mobility work: hip flexors, thoracic spine, hamstrings, shoulders
- Steps count — 8–10k daily is the target, including off days

Cardio — How It Fits

If you're using this program alongside The Standard Fat Loss System, your cardio structure is already built in. If you're using this program on its own:

Session	What	When
LISS	35–45 min zone 2 walk, bike, or rower — conversational pace	One of your active recovery days
Intervals	20 min: 30s hard / 90s easy × 8–10 rounds	One off day — not the day before a heavy lower session
Steps	8–10k daily — start at your current average + 2k	Every day, non-negotiable

Cardio doesn't earn food and it isn't punishment. It's a tool. Steps are the most underrated tool in that kit.

Sleep

Seven-plus hours is not a wellness tip — it's a training requirement. Muscle repair, hormone regulation, and cortisol reset all happen during sleep. If you're consistently sleeping under 6 hours, no amount of training will fully compensate.

- Consistent wake time matters more than consistent bedtime — your body sets its rhythm from when you wake, not when you sleep
- Phone out of arm's reach — light exposure from screens suppresses melatonin for up to 90 minutes
- If sleep is a 4/10, fix that before adding any additional training volume

You don't get stronger in the gym. You get stronger recovering from the gym.

STRONG NOT SORRY · 8-WEEK STRENGTH PROGRAM

PROGRESSION RULES

How to know when to add weight — and when not to

08

"Stability over intensity."

08 — PROGRESSION

The only way this works is if you progress.

Progressive overload is the principle that drives every result in this program. You have to give your body a reason to change. The reason is that the work keeps getting slightly harder over time.

Slightly is the key word. This is not about chasing max lifts or adding weight every single session. It's about a consistent, manageable increase over 8 weeks.

The rule: hit the top of the rep range on every set with two reps left in the tank — add 5–10% next session. That's it. No exceptions, no guessing.

When to Add Weight

Situation	What It Means	What to Do
Hit top of rep range, 2+ reps left, form was solid	You're ready to progress	Add 5 lbs (upper body) or 10 lbs (lower body) next session
Hit top of rep range but form broke down	Weight is too heavy for this stage	Stay at same weight, focus on form for 1 more week
Couldn't hit bottom of rep range	Weight is too heavy	Drop 10% and rebuild
Hit all reps but it felt like a 9–10	Too heavy for the intended stimulus	Drop 5–10% — RPE 7–8 is the target, not max effort
Deload week	Intentional reduction	Drop to 60% — do not try to progress during deload

Tracking Your Weights

Write down what you lifted after every session. The weight, the reps, how it felt on a 1–10 scale. You cannot manage what you don't measure, and two weeks from now you will not remember what you squatted on a Tuesday.

- Use the notes app on your phone, a notebook, or the Strong Not Sorry app — whatever you'll actually use
- Log: exercise, weight, sets completed, reps completed, RPE
- Review it before your next session — not after

Form over weight. Every time. A lighter weight done correctly builds more strength than a heavier weight done wrong.

Questions about the program? Find me on Instagram @christin_fisher. If you want the full picture — training plus nutrition plus fat loss — grab The Standard Fat Loss System or Built for This. — Christin This program is general fitness guidance, not medical advice. Check with your doctor before starting a new training program, especially if you have existing health conditions.